

HONG KONG MAHJONG

The most widely played Mahjong ruleset, originating in Guangdong (Cantonese) China. Four players compete to assemble a winning hand of melds and a pair from a shared pool of 144 tiles.

THE TILES

Suited tiles (108): Three suits of nine values each, four copies per value.

SUIT	NAME	VALUES
Characters (Wan, 萬)	Also called Man or Crack	1-9
Bamboo (Sou, 索)	Also called Bam	1-9
Circles (Pin, 筒)	Also called Dot	1-9

Honour tiles (28): Four copies of each.

TYPE	TILES
Winds	East, South, West, North
Dragons	White (Bai), Green (Fa), Red (Zhong)

Bonus tiles (8): Set aside when drawn, not part of a winning hand.

- Flowers: 1(Spring), 2(Summer), 3(Autumn), 4(Winter)
- Seasons: 1(Plum), 2(Orchid), 3(Chrysanthemum), 4(Bamboo)

Each bonus tile number corresponds to a seat: 1 = East, 2 = South, 3 = West, 4 = North.

SEATING AND ROUND WIND

Seats are East, South, West, and North. East is the dealer and moves first. The round wind (East, South, West, or North) rotates after all four players have been dealer. The game covers at least one East round; full games include all four rounds.

DEALING

Shuffle all 144 tiles face down and build a wall of four sides, two tiles high and 18 tiles wide per side. East rolls dice to determine the break point.

Each player draws 13 tiles clockwise from the wall, starting with East. East then draws one extra tile to begin the game (or draws first on their turn). Bonus tiles are set aside immediately and a replacement tile is drawn from the live wall.

TURN STRUCTURE

On your turn:

- 1 **Draw** one tile from the wall (or claim a discarded tile, see Claiming below).
- 2 **Bonus tile:** if the drawn tile is a flower or season, set it aside and draw a replacement.
- 3 **Declare a winning hand** if your 14 tiles form a valid hand (see Winning).
- 4 **Declare a Kong** if you hold a complete set of four identical tiles, then draw a supplement tile and discard.
- 5 **Discard** one tile face-up to the centre.

CLAIMING DISCARDS

After any discard, other players may claim it in priority order (highest to lowest):

- 1 **Win (any player):** claim the discard to complete a valid winning hand.
- 2 **Kong (any player):** claim four identical tiles to declare an open Kong. Draw a supplement tile, then discard.
- 3 **Pong (any player):** claim three identical tiles (2 in hand + discard). Discard one tile.
- 4 **Chow (left-hand player only):** claim to complete a sequence of three consecutive suited tiles. Discard one tile.

Only one player may claim each discard. If no one claims, the next player draws from the wall.

MELDS

MELD	DESCRIPTION	NOTES
Chow	Sequence of 3 consecutive tiles of the same suit	From left player only; suited tiles only
Pong	3 identical tiles	From any player
Kong	4 identical tiles	From any player; draw supplement tile

Concealed Pongs and Kongs (formed from drawn tiles, never claimed from a discard) score higher than open melds.

Robbing the Kong: when a player upgrades a Pong to a Kong by drawing the fourth tile, any other player who can win by taking that tile may declare an immediate win, robbing the Kong.

WINNING HAND

A standard winning hand consists of **4 melds + 1 pair = 14 tiles**.

Alternate winning hands: Seven Pairs (7 different pairs), and certain limit hands defined by the scoring table.

To declare a win, the hand must be worth a **minimum of 3 faan**.

Win on wall (Zimo): you draw the winning tile from the wall. All three opponents each pay the full hand value.

Win on discard (Ron): another player discards your winning tile. Only the discarder pays the full hand value.

BONUS TILES (FLOWERS AND SEASONS)

Bonus tiles are set aside when drawn and are not part of the winning hand structure. They provide bonus faan:

CONDITION	FAAN
Own-seat flower or season (matching seat number)	1
All four flowers	5
All four seasons	5
All eight bonus tiles	Automatic win (limit hand)

FAAN SCORING

Each winning hand is valued by adding up the faan from completed patterns. Common patterns:

PATTERN	FAAN
Self-draw win (Zimo)	1
Fully concealed hand	1
All Pongs	3
Half Flush (one suit + honours)	3
Full Flush (one suit only)	6
Mixed Terminals and Honours	1
All Terminals and Honours	5
Seven Pairs	3
Winning on a supplement tile (after Kong)	1
Winning on last tile of the wall	1
Robbing a Kong	1

Minimum to win: **3 faan**. A hand below 3 faan cannot be declared.

LIMIT HANDS

Certain exceptional hands pay the maximum regardless of calculated faan. Examples: Thirteen Orphans, Four Concealed Pongs, All Kongs. When a limit hand is declared, each opponent pays the maximum limit amount.

PAYMENT

Payment is in points (chips or tallies). The East player (dealer) pays and receives double.

- ♦ Win on discard: discarder pays full hand value; others pay nothing.
- ♦ Win on wall: all three opponents each pay full hand value.
- ♦ Dealer wins or loses: dealer pays or receives double the usual amount.

The dealer role passes to the left (South becomes dealer) when the dealer does not win the hand. The dealer retains their seat if they win.

ATTRIBUTION

Hong Kong / Cantonese Mahjong. Traditional game originating in China. Rules in the public domain. Primary source: Wikipedia (*Mahjong*), Hong Kong ruleset section.